Eric Cantona came up to me while I was getting changed and shook my hand:

‘What a goal,’ he said.

Believe me, that felt even better than scoring it. Someone from *Match Of the Day* wanted to speak to me but the boss said he didn’t want me talking to anyone. So I went straight out to get on the team bus. Because the game was in London, Mum, Dad and Joanne were waiting for me. I’ve got a photo of the goal at home, of the ball just hanging against the clear, blue sky, and I can actually see my mum and dad in the crowd. I got to the steps of the bus and Dad hugged me:

‘I can’t believe you’ve just done that!’

That evening, I talked on the phone to Helen, who was at college down in Bristol:

‘Did you score a goal today? Everybody here’s talking about it, saying you’ve scored this great goal.’

People were coming up to me in the street all weekend and saying the same thing. I couldn’t have known it then, but that moment was the start of it all: the attention, the press coverage, the fame, that whole side of what’s happened to me since. It changed forever that afternoon in South London, with one swing of a new boot. The thrill I get playing soccer, my love of the game: those things will always be there. But there’s hardly anything else—for better or worse—that has been the same since. When my foot struck that ball, it kicked open the door to the rest of my life at the same time. In the game, it eventually dropped down out of the air and into the net. In the life of David Beckham, it feels like the ball is still up there. And I’m still watching it swerve and dip through a perfect, clear afternoon sky: watching and waiting to see where it’s going to come down to land.